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SECURITY



Google, Microsoft say Chinese hackers are exploiting SharePoint zero-day

Security researchers at Google and Microsoft say they have evidence that hackers backed by China are [exploiting a zero-day bug in Microsoft SharePoint](#), as companies around the world scramble to patch the flaw.

The bug, known officially as [CVE-2025-53770](#) and [discovered last weekend](#), allows hackers to steal sensitive private keys from self-hosted versions of SharePoint, a software server widely used by companies and organizations to store and share internal documents. Once exploited, an attacker can use the bug to remotely plant malware and gain access to the files and data stored within, as well as gain access to other systems on the same network.

In [a blog post on Tuesday](#), Microsoft said it had observed at least two previously identified China-backed hacking groups it calls “Linen Typhoon” and “Violet Typhoon” exploiting the SharePoint zero-day. Microsoft says Linen Typhoon is focused on stealing intellectual property, while Violet Typhoon steals private information to be used for espionage.

Microsoft also attributed the ongoing hacks to a third China-backed hacking group it named “Storm-2603,” representing a hacking group about which the company has less information. The company noted, however, that the hackers have been linked to ransomware attacks in the past.

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According to Microsoft, the three hacking groups were observed exploiting the zero-day vulnerability to break into vulnerable SharePoint servers as far back as July 7.

Charles Carmakal, the chief technology officer at Google's incident response unit Mandiant, told TechCrunch in an email that "at least one of the actors responsible" was a China-nexus hacking group, but noted that "multiple actors are now actively exploiting this vulnerability."

Dozens of organizations have already been hacked, [including across the government sector](#). The bug is regarded as a [zero-day](#) because the vendor — Microsoft, in this case — had no time to issue a patch before it was actively exploited. Microsoft has [since rolled out patches for all affected versions of SharePoint](#), but security researchers have warned that customers running self-hosted versions of SharePoint should assume they have already been compromised.

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The Chinese government has long rebuffed allegations that it has carried out cyberattacks, though it has not always explicitly denied its involvement.

When reached for comment, Liu Pengyu, a spokesperson for the Chinese Embassy in Washington, D.C., said in a statement that China “firmly opposes and combats all forms of cyber attacks and cyber crime — a position that is consistent and clear.”

This is the latest hacking campaign linked to China in recent years. Hackers backed by China were accused of targeting self-hosted Microsoft Exchange email servers in 2021 as part of a mass-hacking campaign. According to a [recent Justice Department indictment](#) accusing two Chinese hackers of masterminding the breaches, the so-called “Hafnium” hacks compromised contact information and private mailboxes from more than 60,000 affected servers.

Updated with comment from the Chinese government.

Topics: [China](#) [cyberattacks](#) [cybersecurity](#) [Google](#)

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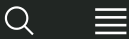
New zero-day bug in Microsoft SharePoint under widespread attack

Zack Whittaker — 5:50 AM PDT · July 21, 2025

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across the world largely unable to defend against the ongoing intrusions.

Microsoft said the bug, known officially as [CVE-2025-53770](#), affects versions of SharePoint that companies set up and manage on their own servers. SharePoint lets companies store, share, and manage their internal files.

Microsoft said it is working on security fixes to prevent hackers from exploiting the vulnerability. The flaw, described as a “[zero-day](#)” because the vendor was given no time to patch the bug before it was made aware of it, affects versions of the software as old as SharePoint Server 2016.

It’s not yet known how many servers have been compromised so far, but it is likely thousands of small to medium-sized businesses that rely on the software are affected. According to [The Washington Post](#), several U.S. federal agencies, universities, and energy companies have already been breached in the attacks.

Eye Security, which [first revealed the bug](#) on Saturday, said it found “dozens” of actively exploited Microsoft SharePoint servers online at the time of its publication. The bug, when exploited, allows hackers to steal private digital keys from SharePoint servers without needing any credentials to log in. Once in, the hackers can remotely plant malware and gain access to the files and data stored within. Eye Security warned that SharePoint connects with other apps, like Outlook, Teams, and OneDrive, which may enable further network compromise and data theft.

Eye Security said because the bug involves the theft of digital keys that can be used to impersonate legitimate requests on the server, affected customers must both patch the bug and take additional steps to rotate their digital keys to

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prevent the hackers from recompromising the server.

CISA and others have urged customers to “take immediate recommended action.” In the absence of patches or mitigations, customers should consider disconnecting potentially affected systems from the internet.

“If you have SharePoint [on-premise] exposed to the internet, you should assume that you have been compromised at this point,” said Michael Sikorski, the head of Palo Alto Networks’ threat intelligence division Unit 42, in an email to TechCrunch.

It’s also not yet known who is carrying out the attacks on SharePoint servers, but it is the latest in a string of cyberattacks targeting Microsoft customers in recent years.

In 2021, a China-backed hacking group dubbed Hafnium was caught exploiting a vulnerability found in self-hosted Microsoft Exchange email servers, allowing [the mass-hacking and exfiltration of email and contacts data from businesses](#) around the world. The hackers compromised more than 60,000 servers, according to a [recent Justice Department indictment](#) accusing two Chinese nationals of masterminding the operation.

Two years later, Microsoft confirmed a cyberattack on its cloud systems, which it manages directly, allowing Chinese hackers to [steal a sensitive email signing key](#) that permitted access to both consumer and enterprise email accounts hosted by the company.

Microsoft has also reported [repeated intrusions](#) from hackers associated with the Russian government.

*Do you know more about the SharePoint
cyberattacks? Are you an affected customer?
Securely contact this reporter via encrypted
message at [zackwhittaker.1337](#) on Signal.*

*An earlier version of this story stated the incorrect
CVE number; the story has been amended to note
the correct vulnerability, CVE-2025-53770.*

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Hundreds of
organizations breached

by SharePoint mass-hacks

Zack Whittaker — 6:32 AM PDT · July 23, 2025

Security researchers say hackers have breached at least 400 organizations by exploiting a zero-day vulnerability in Microsoft SharePoint, signaling a sharp rise in the number of detected compromises since the bug was discovered last week.

Eye Security, a Dutch cybersecurity firm that first identified the vulnerability in SharePoint, a popular server software that companies use to store and share internal documents, said it had identified hundreds of affected SharePoint servers by scanning the internet. The number has risen from the dozens of known compromised servers as of earlier this week.

Bloomberg reports that one of the affected organizations includes the National Nuclear Security Administration (NNSA), the federal agency responsible for maintaining and developing the U.S. stockpile of nuclear weapons. Ben Dietderich, a spokesperson for the Department of Energy, which houses the NNSA, confirmed the department was “minimally impacted,” and that a “very small number of systems were impacted.”

Several other government departments and agencies were also compromised in an early wave of attacks exploiting the SharePoint bug,

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researchers confirmed. Data suggests hackers were exploiting the vulnerability as early as July 7.

The bug, officially known as [CVE-2025-53770](#), affects self-hosted versions of SharePoint that companies set up and manage on their own servers. Once exploited, the bug allows an attacker to remotely run malicious code on the affected server, permitting access to the files stored inside, as well as other systems on the company's wider network.

The vulnerability is known as a [zero-day](#) because Microsoft had no time to release patches before it was exploited. Microsoft has since released patches for all affected SharePoint versions.

Google and Microsoft say they have evidence that [several China-backed hacking groups are exploiting the bug](#), but warned companies to expect an uptick in compromises as more hacker groups seek to take advantage of the vulnerability. The Chinese government denied the allegations.

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Updated with comment from the Department of Energy.

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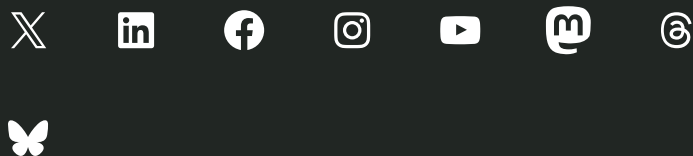
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